

seabed (lay me to rest)

b. phan

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I dream of whitewater spray.

A little cottage by the sea with blue walls and a red door, perched atop a bone white cliff-face embedded with a myriad of multicolored seashells split in perfect halves down the middle, stark and bright against the pale rock. Your fingers in my hair, tangled in the salt-bleached strands, tugging lightly as you tilt my head back, moonlight reflecting in your eyes. Long walks on the beach, arms looped together, easy smiles on our faces and the air between us filled with laughter. Sand between our toes, a white skirt fluttering around my ankles in the gentle ocean breeze. Your cologne sticking to my sweat-slicked neck, calloused palms warm with the lingering sunlight that soaked into your skin. White pickett fence haphazardly driven into loosely packed earth, two-and-a-half kids, a dog and a cat, wine with dinner every night.

I dream of whitewater spray.

A lemon tree in the yard, the fruit too bright and tart and sour to use for anything but looking at. A gravel driveway, small stones that stick to the soles of your feet, dislodged and lost within the house. Warped hardwood floors, a long case of rickety stairs you trip going up to the porthole window at the very, very top of the house. A view of the sea: steel blue, unending, stretching out in every direction like a great reflection of the sky above, waves breaking along the shore—the tide giveth and taketh away. Sometimes, when the moon is full, you are eye-to-eye with it and then you cannot see anything at all; the sea is louder then, closer, a whistling call that speaks to a new sickness in your blood, a familiar song you do not quite know the words to.

I dream of whitewater spray.

An unknowable mirror, dark and fathomless, incomprehensibly deep and swallowing all light into its maw. Silence, deafening silence, that makes my head ring with how loud it is. Riptide rushing beneath me, the event horizon that threatens to pull me in, to take me apart. A siren song, a lighthouse across the shore: *something waits for you beyond the veil*. A step taken forward, two steps taken back—I flee, I climb the cliff-face, the rocks like caltrops dragging along my skin, leaving a trail of red like cherry cordial or bordeaux or a maid on her wedding night along the limestone. I heave myself over the ledge, gravel digging into my palms; I crawl like a dog, back to you.

I dream of whitewater spray.

Blood in the sand. Sea glass shattering, splintering. Calloused, sunwarmed hands around my neck. A distant lighthouse, a bright flame, a shooting star. I want to go there. I want to go there.

I dream of whitewater spray.

Salt in my mouth. It hurts my eyes. Calloused, sunwarmed hands around my neck, fingers tangled in my salt-bleached hair. Steel blue water, skeins of red in the surf. The halves of seashells dig into my palms. Sleep beckons me, compass needle pointing down. The tide ebbs, and I get a mouthful of it all—salt, water, shells. A wave slams into me, you push me down deeper. I raise my eyes to heaven, looking for a God I know does not see me. Polaris glitters like a diamond above me, reflecting and refracting the lighthouse's white-hot flame. Will you let me go there? Will you let me go there?

I dream of whitewater spray.

A burning in my lungs. Freedom.

I dream of whitewater spray.

Fold me in half, dig your fingers into the hollows of my cheeks. Pull me wide open, tilt my head back, make a martyr out of me. Mark my hands with stigmata, press me under heavy glass. Pin me down, a sword through my ribs, Clarent in the stone. Twist me grotesquely, mold me into a mass of splintered bone no one will recognize. In the blackest night, I would know you, and you run me through with a blade, and I hope you catch me before my knees hit the earth, and I hope you hold me so close I cannot tell if the warmth is you or the blood down my front.

I dream of whitewater spray.

For years now, I've had the same dream: overlooking a sea of evergreen peaks illuminated by a silky moonlight hue, winding a long, narrow road darkened on both sides by tightly clustered trees, my arms wrapped around my chest, cold layered like a skin, sinking deep into my bones, cold wet like a damp hate; trees clustered around my wandering soul, spurned into wandering like a little undead ghost with teeth clattering in Morse code, saying: *so many wrongs done*, it is *almost incomprehensible*.

Is it too much to ask to be wanted?

I need it like air.

For years now, I've had the same dream: a dream of being a lighthouse keeper, skin saltwater slick, seafoam on the backs of my knuckles, slathering over frozen fingers clutching at the gallery railing. Beckoning something to me. What it is, I do not know.

I dream of—

—meeting you again.